INDIA TODAY S2

STATE OF THE STATE

UTTARAKHAND FIRST

> "We have to develop Uttarakhand as it was born on the slogan of development...but not at the cost of environment"

HILLSIDE VIEWS

As Uttarakhand strives towards becoming an industrial, tourist and spiritual hub, experts deliberate on how to expedite this transformation while conserving the hill state's fragile ecology

Uttarakhand aspires to become a Rs 3.3 lakh crore economy this year with a 10 per cent growth rate. And it wants to achieve this by striking a balance between the development and conservation needs of the Himalayan state. The chief minister, Pushkar Singh Dhami, agrees. Speaking at the INDIA TODAY State of the State Uttarakhand First conclave held in Dehradun on August 25, Dhami shared his vision of transforming Uttarakhand into the Switzerland of India by building infrastructure to promote tourism and accelerating manufacturing in the plains. After all, roughly half of the state's GDP comes from the activities in its factories. Home to numerous temples and pristine mountains, the Devbhoomi, as it is called, also has an immense tourism potential. "But not at the cost of environment," cautioned Dhami.

The fragility of the state's ecology, which was again laid bare by the spate of flash floods and landslides this monsoon, remained the talking point during the day-long event that saw three former chief ministers, bureaucrats, industrialists, academicians and environmentalists, among others, set the agenda for the young state. In about two months from now, Uttarakhand will be hosting a Global Investors Summit, having set an ambitious target of inviting investments worth Rs 2.5 lakh crore. Chief secretary Sukhbir Singh Sandhu detailed the steps being taken to strengthen the state's infrastructure to support these investments.

Earlier, Dhami also talked of creating new employment opportunities within the state to stop the migration of its local talent. The CM's efforts to facilitate the 'peace of doing business' got a stamp of approval from the industrialists, while Patanjali CEO Acharya Balkrishna said how Uttarakhand has the potential to become a global manufacturing hub for Ayurveda products. As for tourism, a key takeaway was that the state should aspire for quality instead of quantity to conserve its rich biodiversity and avert natural disasters. ■

Photographs by RAJWANT RAWAT, KUSHAGRA WADHWA

▼ SETTING THE AGENDA



> "Uttarakhand today has a wide network of roads... telecom connectivity is being enhanced by PM Narendra Modi. The process of reverse migration has begun in the hill state"

BHAGAT SINGH KOSHYARI
Former chief minister, Uttarakhand, and ex-governor, Maharashtra

